BACK OF THE SLEEVE

The 25 Wildest Song Stories

True stories from the back of the sleeve. Twenty-five songs, twenty-five true stories, each with its sources.

BEFORE YOU START

Every song has a back story

These are 25 true stories from music history: the accidents, rumours, arguments and lucky breaks behind songs you know.

Every story was checked against the sources listed under it. Where a story is disputed, we say so.

If you spot a mistake, tell us at the address on our contact page and we will review it.

New stories land every week on our YouTube channel and on backofthesleeve.com.

1 Bohemian Rhapsody

Queen

The label said nobody would play a six-minute single.

Queen's manager and label thought the 5 minute 55 second song was too long for radio and wanted it cut. Instead the band gave a reel-to-reel copy to Capital Radio DJ Kenny Everett, who agreed not to play it. In October 1975 he played it 14 times in two days. Record shops were swamped on the Monday for a single that had not been released yet. It came out uncut.

Sources: Wikipedia: Bohemian Rhapsody · The Independent

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2 Smells Like Teen Spirit

Nirvana

The title started as a joke about deodorant.

Bikini Kill's Kathleen Hanna and Tobi Vail laughed at a deodorant called Teen Spirit in a shop. That night Hanna wrote 'Kurt smells like Teen Spirit' on Kurt Cobain's wall in marker. Cobain later asked if he could use it for a song. He told his biographer he did not know the deodorant existed until months after the single came out.

Sources: Double J: Kathleen Hanna on naming the song · Biography.com

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3 Louie Louie

The Kingsmen

The FBI investigated a party song.

In 1964 rumours spread that the slurred words of the Kingsmen's 'Louie Louie' hid obscene lyrics, and the FBI opened an investigation. Its laboratory played the record at different speeds and in May 1965 declared the words unintelligible. The song is actually about a sailor missing his girl.

Sources: BBC News: Smashed Hits: Louie Louie · HISTORY: The FBI weighs in on Louie Louie

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4 Yesterday

The Beatles

Paul McCartney thought he had stolen it from a dream.

McCartney woke with the whole melody in his head and rushed to a piano. Sure he must have heard it somewhere, he spent about a month playing it to people in the music business, asking if they knew it. He said it felt like handing something in to the police. Nobody claimed it. Until proper words came, the working lyric was 'Scrambled Eggs'.

Sources: Wikipedia: Yesterday (song) · mccartney.com: Yesterday

5 Stairway to Heaven

Led Zeppelin

Years in court over the opening notes.

The estate of Spirit guitarist Randy Wolfe claimed the opening of 'Stairway to Heaven' copied his song 'Taurus'. A jury sided with Led Zeppelin in 2016. After an appeal and a rehearing, a full U.S. appeals court backed the band again on March 9, 2020, by a 9 to 2 vote.

Sources: Reuters · Ninth Circuit opinion

6 Sweet Child o' Mine

Guns N' Roses

A riff nobody took seriously.

It began with Slash noodling on a riff at the band's house. Izzy Stradlin added chord changes and Axl Rose heard it and wrote the lyrics. Slash has pushed back on the popular 'warm-up exercise' story, and Duff McKagan has said the riff started as a joke and that Slash wanted to get rid of the song.

Sources: Guitar World: how Slash came up with the riff · Ultimate Classic Rock: Duff McKagan

7 Born in the U.S.A.

Bruce Springsteen

A protest song that politicians heard as a flag-waver.

The verses tell of a Vietnam War veteran who comes home to unemployment and a country that forgets him. The shouted chorus is defiant, not triumphant. In September 1984 President Reagan praised Springsteen's 'message of hope' at a New Jersey campaign stop, and the song's meaning has been argued about ever since.

Sources: NPR: What does Born in the U.S.A. really mean? · New Jersey Monthly

8 Back in Black

AC/DC

A new singer and a black cover for the one they lost.

Singer Bon Scott died in February 1980. By April the band had recruited former Geordie singer Brian Johnson, recorded the album in the Bahamas and released it in July 1980. The all-black cover was a mourning tribute to Scott, while the music was meant to celebrate him.

Sources: Louder: the inside story of Back in Black · The Guardian: AC/DC recruits Brian Johnson

9 Layla

Derek and the Dominos

A rock classic built on a 12th-century Persian love story.

Eric Clapton wrote it for Pattie Boyd, who was then married to his friend George Harrison. The title comes from Nizami's 12th-century Persian poem about Layla and Majnun, a tale of obsessive, unreachable love. Duane Allman joined the sessions and his slide guitar helped turn a ballad into the rock track we know.

Sources: Leiden University: a Persian love story and a rock classic · Wikipedia: Layla (song)

10 Don't Stop Believin'

Journey

The title waits almost to the very end.

In Journey's original recording the words 'Don't stop believin'' do not arrive until the final chorus, about 3 minutes 20 seconds in, with roughly 50 seconds left. Everything before it builds the tension.

Sources: Wikipedia: Don't Stop Believin' · Songfacts

11 The Sound of Silence

Simon & Garfunkel

A producer added a band without telling them.

The acoustic song had flopped. Columbia producer Tom Wilson overdubbed electric guitar, bass and drums onto it without Simon and Garfunkel knowing. The new version was released in 1965 and reached number one on the Billboard Hot 100 in the week ending January 1, 1966.

Sources: Official Simon & Garfunkel site · Smithsonian Magazine

12 Space Oddity

David Bowie

Released five days before the moon launch.

Bowie's song about an astronaut lost in space came out on July 11, 1969, five days before Apollo 11 launched. The BBC used it in its coverage of the landing, then kept it off further radio play until the crew was safely back on Earth, because the theme seemed unsuitable during the mission.

Sources: Smithsonian: Bowie soundtracked the moon landing · BBC Culture

13 Every Breath You Take

The Police

The wedding song that is really about control.

Sting wrote it in 1982 while staying at GoldenEye in Jamaica, the former home of James Bond author Ian Fleming. He has described it as a song about surveillance, jealousy and possession. It sounds warm and gentle, and many people have taken it for a love song.

Sources: MusicRadar: the story behind the song · uDiscover Music

14 'Heroes'

David Bowie

A kiss by the Berlin Wall, or maybe not.

The best-known story says Bowie wrote it after seeing his producer Tony Visconti kiss Antonia Maass near the Berlin Wall while they recorded at Hansa Studios. Visconti has told that story and Bowie confirmed it. Maass has reportedly said the song was finished before then, and a 2024 documentary points to another day Bowie spent with a different woman as inspiration for the lyric. The origin is disputed.

Sources: davidbowie.com: 'Heroes' is forty · The Guardian (2024)

15 Hey Jude

The Beatles

Written to cheer up John Lennon's young son.

Paul McCartney wrote it to comfort Julian Lennon after his parents separated. The original title was 'Hey Jules'. At 7 minutes 11 seconds it was then the longest single to reach number one in the U.K. and the U.S., and it spent nine weeks at number one in America.

Sources: TheBeatles.com: Hey Jude · Wikipedia: Hey Jude

16 Like a Rolling Stone

Bob Dylan

The organist was not supposed to be there.

On June 16, 1965 Al Kooper came to the session as a guitarist but felt outplayed by Mike Bloomfield. He slipped onto the organ stool instead and improvised a part, even though he was not an organist. Producer Tom Wilson objected, but Dylan asked for the organ to be turned up. The six-minute single became a landmark.

Sources: Library of Congress: That's Kooper, not Cooper · NPR: The Day Dylan Got It Right

17 Shine On You Crazy Diamond

Pink Floyd

The man the song was about walked into the studio.

On June 5, 1975, while Pink Floyd were mixing the song written for their former leader Syd Barrett, a heavier man with a shaved head and eyebrows arrived at Abbey Road. At first they did not recognise him. It was Barrett. Roger Waters is reported to have cried. Barrett said the song sounded a bit old and left without saying goodbye.

Sources: Louder: Syd Barrett's surprise visit · Sound on Sound: Classic Tracks

18 Ring of Fire

Johnny Cash

The trumpets came in a dream.

June Carter and Merle Kilgore wrote it, and Anita Carter recorded it first in 1962 as '(Love's) Ring of Fire'. Johnny Cash said he heard it in a dream with Mexican-style horns, and in 1963 he recorded his version with mariachi trumpets.

Sources: Rolling Stone · Wikipedia: Ring of Fire (song)

19 Go Your Own Way

Fleetwood Mac

A breakup song sung in front of the person it was about.

Lindsey Buckingham wrote it about his breakup with bandmate Stevie Nicks while the two kept working together on Rumours. Nicks hated the line 'Packing up, shacking up is all you wanna do', saying it was unfair to her. She asked him to cut it. He kept it.

Sources: Sound on Sound: Classic Tracks · American Songwriter

20 Sweet Caroline

Neil Diamond

The Caroline behind the song stayed secret for decades.

In 2007 Neil Diamond revealed the song was inspired by a magazine photo of Caroline Kennedy as a child in riding clothes with her pony, on the cover of LIFE dated September 7, 1962. Fenway Park began playing it in 1997, and it became a Boston tradition.

Sources: The Guardian (2007) · MLB.com: Fenway's anthem

21 American Pie

Don McLean

The handwritten pages sold for $1.2 million.

'The day the music died' refers to the plane crash of February 3, 1959 that killed Buddy Holly, Ritchie Valens and J.P. 'The Big Bopper' Richardson. In 2015 McLean's working manuscript, with handwritten changes and an unrecorded verse, sold at Christie's in New York for about $1.2 million.

Sources: Reuters · Christie's

22 Hurt

Johnny Cash

The writer said the song was not his anymore.

Johnny Cash recorded Nine Inch Nails' 'Hurt' for his 2002 album American IV. Trent Reznor says he found the idea strange at first. After seeing the music video he said, 'I just lost my girlfriend, because that song isn't mine anymore.'

Sources: Stereogum: American IV turns 20 · American Songwriter

23 Another One Bites the Dust

Queen

Michael Jackson told them to release it.

Bassist John Deacon wrote it around a bassline inspired by Chic's 'Good Times'. Queen doubted it would work as a single. Michael Jackson, a fan who came to their Los Angeles shows, urged them to release it. It came out in August 1980 and became their second U.S. number one.

Sources: Billboard · Ultimate Classic Rock

24 Under Pressure

Queen and David Bowie

Born in a jam, then sampled without credit.

Queen and Bowie recorded it at Mountain Studios in Montreux, Switzerland, in 1981 after a spontaneous jam. In 1990 Vanilla Ice's 'Ice Ice Baby' used its bassline without credit. After Queen and Bowie threatened to sue, the matter was settled and they received credit and royalties.

Sources: Biography.com: the recording session · GW Law: Queen & Bowie v. Vanilla Ice

25

Hybrid Theory

Linkin Park

Their singer was hired over a phone call.

Music executive Jeff Blue called Chester Bennington in Phoenix in 1999 about joining the band then called Xero. Chester recorded vocals over their demo and sang a section down the phone line. Blue was impressed and arranged for him to come to Los Angeles for a formal audition. Labels had turned the band down more than 40 times before Warner Bros. signed them. Read the full story on our site.

Sources: Rolling Stone: David Fricke on Hybrid Theory · Louder: Chester Bennington's road to success

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